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FireDistinguishers



Congress 509: How to lobby with an internet connection and a \$3 post card

Effortpost

Introduction

I'm back bitches. Did you miss me? Four months of no activity on this series and here we are.

But why here? Why lobbying again? Well, based on some of the comments I've seen recently **some of you** didn't learn your fucking lesson the first time, and based on other comments **I didn't teach you the more practical lesson anyway**, so let's run it again. Welcome to Congressional Kindergarten, I'm Mr. Firedistinguishers, I'm now (technically) a Special Advisor on Procedure in the United States Senate, and this will be the only story before naptime, but here are the links to the old posts anyway:

[Part 6](#) [Part 5](#) [Part 4](#) [Part 3](#) [Part 2](#) [Part 1](#) [Part 0](#)

What is Lobbying

[Read this.](#)

It's my best post yet in my opinion. It's about what Lobbying is and why it's **not** what you think it is, and why it **is** what you think it is. I had legal definitions, links to places where you could look up documentation of lobbying activities for yourself with examples from my personal research, explanations of what meetings look like with lobbyists, it was amazing. Did you read it? Great stuff in there. Real easy way to shit on people's egos by shoving all that evidence that they don't know what they're talking about right in their face. That's what the sub's all about man, just do it.

If you want the abridged version:

Lobbying is whenever someone reaches out to a covered official ([defined in the post](#)) to ask them to make, change, or adopt a rule, regulation, program, or policy.

You call your Rep and say "take us back to Afghanistan!" That's lobbying.

But I can't do that: A story in five sentences

"Oh but Firedistinguishers," said Downer Debbie, "I'm just a little itty bitty bitch and these fat cats are the real problem, boo hoo, I can't buy out 20 elections like they can."

"Fuck you," said Firedistinguishers, "Learn what those fat cats are called, and that campaign donations don't mean shit to 2/3 places where lobbying happens [by reading the fucking post](#)."

"Ehrrm, excuse me, Firedistinguishers," said Smug Samuel, "Are you really trying to insinuate that people like us are as capable at influencing policy as those 'fat cats' as you say?"

"No." said Firedistinguishers, "They are better than you at the thing they do 40 hours a week for pay."

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I'll be taking my Newbery medal to-go.

So you want to be a lobbyist

Let's assume nothing except you have an issue you want to change at the policy level. What issue? Irrelevant. Which policy? Irrelevant. At what level of government? Irrelevant. Who are you? Irrelevant. How do you do it? Here are the general steps (stolen from a friend working as a lobbyist in the private sector).

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Pick the topic of interest for the advocacy idea you have. For example: If you have an idea about learning loss in Universities, then you can say the issue broadly touches Higher-Ed, Teacher Prep, Racial Equity, Public Health, and even Tax Allocations.		
Description: Topics		A list of five topical areas related to the issue
Description: Issue	Write a summary (in three to five sentences) about exactly what the issue is that needs to be addressed.	A short description of the issue
Description: Stakeholders	Identify groups that are impacted by the issue. At this stage of the process you should keep these groups as local as possible (avoid things like "American college students" or "suburban Americans,"). Instead, define groups like college students at X University, or computer science majors in Y state, constituents of district Z, small businesses in city A, etc.	A list of groups that are impacted by the issue
Description: Decision Makers	Identify the people, and groups of people, that have influence over the issue. You could define things like US Senators, state legislators, a university's board of regents, a city council, a union, a home owners association, or a school board	A list of people or groups of people that have influence over the issue
Description: Potential Solutions	Identify the actions that could improve the situation that the issue has created.	A list of solutions to the problem you've identified
Description: Relationships	This step is critical. Link each solution you identified to a decision maker, and then link each solution to the concerned groups it would impact the most. Use this time to figure out who and what influences who else and what else.	Links between the lists you formulated in previous steps
Research: Timelines	Research timelines that decision makers are subject to. For example, certain state legislatures only meet for certain months in the year, university regents only have a few meetings each year, and even "perpetually operating" bodies like Congress are subject to timelines of action like the Budget cycle (read more about that here).	A calendar that will help you plan when you can make your changes
Research: Allies and Opposition	Research the organizations and people among concerned groups that could be allies or opposition to your efforts. This list could include groups like unions, interest groups, departments at local universities, PTAs, people who live in a certain geographic area, people who work in a particular industry, the list goes on. Don't worry about making an exhaustive list, it takes years to figure out who likes and who doesn't like things, but knowing even one ally or opponent beforehand makes your job easier.	A list of potential allies and potential opponents

Your representatives are on your side, even if they do not

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Representatives	relations with people who are legally mandated to help you because they represent you will make the job of reaching other decision makers significantly easier. Identify your city, county, state, and Federal representatives.	various levels of government
Research: Representatives' Priorities	Use the list of topical areas you wrote up earlier and find overlaps with the issues listed on your representatives' websites, official statements, and even their social media. Even if you don't agree in full, finding common ground makes your job easier.	Links between your and your representatives' priorities
Description II	Revise and edit the issue description you wrote earlier, incorporating information that you learned through background research.	A revised description of the issue
Communication Prep: Summarizing the Ask	Summarize the particular solution to your issue that you have formulated in previous steps in a summary no longer than 500 words.	A summary of your idea
Communication Prep: Summarizing the Background	Summarize the reason a solution is needed in the first place, including a summary of the issue that requires solving, again in no more than 500 words.	A summary of the motivation for your idea, and the issue it solves
Communication Prep: Personal Stories	Contact people from concerned groups and ask them to tell a story about how the issue impacts them personally. You should also consider including any of your own stories involving this topic. If you've ever read my comments in the DT you'll notice that the meetings I talk about aren't the ones with the best policy, they're the ones with the most impactful story about the constituents' problem.	A collection of stories that will highlight the real impact of the issue you want to solve
Go Public: Allies	Contact potential allies with an invitation to collaborate. Be mindful that people will have more expertise than you, and might have worked really hard on this issue before you. Be respectful in tone in whatever communication you send, and share your summary of the ask and summary of the background, inviting them to weigh in. Essentially, show them everything you've done on your own, and volunteer your hand in working with them on shared efforts. 99 times out of 100, they'll be happy there's someone new they can work with, and (if you did your homework) 999 times out of 1000 they'll be excited that their new ally knows what they're doing.	Ideally: a connection with other people trying to solve the same problem in the same way.
Go Public: Meeting	Arrange meetings with the decision makers you identified in previous steps. If these decision makers are your representatives at any level of government, you usually have the legal right to ask for a meeting with them or their staff	Ideally: a meeting

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along to your representatives. In that scenario, be as respectfully pursuant to a meeting with them anyway.

Tips for working with Congress specifically

I never worked in my state's capital, but even if I did there are 49 others I wouldn't know shit about. Same goes for my county council, even if I knew it like the back of my hand it wouldn't mean shit for all the other ones in the country.

I'm very fortunate, however, to have worked in a place, and in a role, where I would be taking meetings with people doing exactly what I described that also just so happens to be the only one of its kind. There's a single United States Congress, and even though every office is different ([which is the catchphrase in this post btw](#)) there are some realities that are always the case on the Hill. Registered Lobbyists use these things to their advantage, and they're very good at it. It's often the case that they would have spent time doing the job of the person they're talking to, so they know exactly what's going on. If you aren't one of the six people on this sub who I know work(ed) in Congress, odds are you're playing at a disadvantage. I can't give you the experience I, or any of them, have. I can give you a few shortcut tips that will level the playing field a little bit.

Work cell # > Extension # > Email > Main Office #

Everybody on the Hill is issued a cell phone. It's been this way since the early 2000s at least with Blackberrys. Nowadays they're iPhones. This is the most coveted method of contact because it's on us 24/7, and if a constituent is calling it we can't ignore them. I've had one of these things for almost 3 years and I've only given the number to 2 people. Everybody else only had the number because we worked in the same office. If a Hill staffer gives you this number, they have just offered to be your slave.

Everybody on the Hill also has a direct extension that goes through their Member of Congress' (MoC's) Office. It's a landline, on our desk, in the Capitol office complex. We use the things constantly to talk to other offices on the Hill, they're pretty sophisticated for how analog they are, and if we're in the office we will pick up. That being said, if we're anywhere but at our desk there's no way we'll pick up, so with these things there's no expectation to answer.

Everybody's email on the Hill is some variation of their name followed by some variation of where they work. If my legal name was Fire Distinguishers, and I worked in the House for *anyone* my email would be fire.distinguishers@mail.house.gov. Senate emails are more distinct and depend on knowing who the individual person works for. Same thing, if my legal name was Fire Distinguishers, but the year is 2007 and I work in the Senate for Biden, my email would be fire_distinguishers@biden.senate.gov. I'll explain why I didn't give the name of a sitting Senator in the next paragraph.

The least coveted and the easiest accessible method of immediate contact is the main office number for any MoC. The reason LCs and LAs aren't interested in keeping it close to our chests is because we don't pick up those calls. Interns and Staff Assistants do. When you call this number and give an opinion, your opinion is logged in Intranet Quorum (IQ), a software that specifically helps Hill staff do their job. *Some* MoCs regularly check the data they get from IQ, meaning calling the main office number and giving your opinion will be of interest to *some* MoCs. Do you know when it will and when it won't? No. So don't take the chance and use a method of contact that is guaranteed to get your opinion in the hands of someone who can do something with

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Healthcare?" or "Hey is Fire Distinguishers still the LC for Foreign Relations?" When I was a Staff Assistant I'd get that call at least once a day.

This is where I advocate the following: **Work your way up this ladder**. Use the main office number to get the name of an LC or an LA. Use their name to write them an email and set up a meeting with them. If they're for one of your representatives they are legally obligated to never say no. If they don't immediately say yes, be respectful of their time but keep asking for meetings. Once you've got one use that meeting to prove you're cooperative about the problem you want solved and serious about solving it. Set up meetings in the future. Build the trust necessary to get their extension or even their work cell number.

Reduced workload > Money

When I first got my job as an LC I worked for a **minimum** of 40 hours a week. I don't mean I was at work for 40 hours a week. I was at work maybe 50 hours a week, of which I spent 40 hours working, 2.5 hours eating, and 7.5 hours goofing off. If there was a national crisis those numbers could double. The volume of things that need to happen on the Hill is unparalleled. So if someone comes up to me and says "Hey I can take care of that," and it turns out they legitimately can, then it's a wrap. I said it in the last post, having someone else write something that my LA was fine with circulating is the closest thing to a bribe I've ever gotten.

If it turns out that your idea is in line with one of your MoC's positions, write a [dear colleague letter](#), take it to a meeting with an LC or an LA, say "I know this is a priority for the office, I've written a dear colleague letter, please feel free to make any changes to it, I just want it to get circulated to raise interest in solving the problem." If you're a good writer I'd say there's a 70% chance they'll make some changes and circulate it. WARNING: Unless you have a legal background, don't bring anyone legal writing. 60% of the time it's committee staff who handle that kind of thing anyway, and the other 40% of the time the work is being done in conjunction with their chamber's legal support office and the Congressional Research Service. Legal writing will be ignored.

Following up means more than reaching out

Everybody says "follow up after your meeting" but the amount of people who take that to mean "write a thank you and never talk to them again" is astounding.

Yes, write a thank you note. Like I said we're all very busy, we took time for you, we like when you acknowledge that. Pro tip, send in thank you mail, a thoughtful letter might be something that the staffer holds on to, reminding them that you mean business. **The best thank you mail is a postcard**. It's distinct enough that it's less likely to be recycled and more likely to be displayed, the message has to be short because there's only so much real estate on those things, and it spends *very little time* in mail inspection because you don't put it in an envelope (meaning we get it quicker).

What following up really means is in a few weeks, or maybe a month, or when your issue isn't in the news cycle, or when Congress is going through a recess like this and the workload is dying down, schedule another meeting. Talk about what's happened since your last one. Offer to help in some kind of way. Bring in more people to talk about the issue and what the solution would mean for them.

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this problem is the topic of conversation.

Conclusions

I will never proofread my work.

The comments will tell me what I left out.

As a US citizen you have more influence over the US Government than you realize.

Obsessing over elections is commonplace on here but it's **useless** at least 50% of the time (depending on the election cycle of whatever you're obsessing over).

Politics should be about making the world better, not an exercise in irrelevantly sharing opinions, complaining about opinions to the contrary, and going to sleep afterwards.

Get your head out of your ass.

Now that I've been promoted I'll go back to writing the old kind of posts and talk about procedure more. Or maybe less because I'll be sick of it.

They should give me a fucking medal for this.

I am vain.

↑ 315 ↓ 54

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FireDistinguishers OP · 5y ago · Edited 5y ago

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**KookyWrangler** • 5y ago

Same thing, if my legal name was Fire Distinguishers, but the year is 2007 and I work in the Senate for Biden, my email would be fire_distinguishers@biden.senate.gov. I'll explain why I didn't give the name of a sitting Senator in the next paragraph.

I don't think you explained

**FireDistinguishers** **OP** • 5y ago

Huh I guess I forgot to. Staff lists are public, insinuating I work for someone who's currently in the chamber is an easy way to dox myself, something I did in my last job (it was a bit of an open secret) and won't be doing with my new office

[+ 1 more reply](#)**Th3_Gruff** • 5y ago

Sweeeeet I've loved reading these! Thanks so much for these dude they're great

**FireDistinguishers** **OP** • 5y ago

Yeah I should do more of these

[+ 1 more reply](#)**DEEEEEETTTTTRRROIIITTT** • 5y ago • Edited 5y ago

[Skip to main content](#)[Find anything](#)[Ask](#)[Log In](#)**FireDistinguishers** OP • 5y ago

yes

and sure, I recommend this comment thread to start

https://www.reddit.com/r/neoliberal/comments/oyp6cl/discussion_thread/h7w15wn/?context=3

+ 2 more replies

**RedRyder360** • 5y ago

From you experience in the senate, what would be the best way to win Krysten Sinema's heart? How many of these meetings what I have to set up before I could go out on a romantic dinner with her?

**FireDistinguishers** OP • 5y ago

This is actually a weird detail I know because the IT specialist in my old office worked concurrently in her office (not uncommon for IT or Human Resources staff on the Senate side, they're assigned to individual offices unlike in the House but usually they're shared by multiple senators)

All her staff use macbooks because she likes the apple ecosystem so I guess beat her in 8ball?

**FireDistinguishers** OP • 5y ago

The fact that you motherfuckers gave this comment an award before the post proves to me this is a dick-first political forum

**Derryn** • 5y ago

I'm sure this is an informative post but man this style of writing just instantly makes me not want to read it lol

**FireDistinguishers** OP • 5y ago

Reasonable.

My entirely commonplace habit of cursing when unnecessary, looking down on people I associate myself with, and tendency to write these long segmented sentences that technically aren't run-ons but are difficult to track anyway aren't admirable.

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[OP the type of guy to buy these books](#)



empvespasian • 5y ago

So I've been looking into the dear colleague letters and I don't think I quite understand them yet. Do these letters present an actual program or law to propose or are they literally only for awareness? Do you have an example of one to look at?



FireDistinguishers [OP](#) • 5y ago

They're just a letter to be circulated among congressional offices. They can be about getting cosponsors for a certain bill, they can be about supporting a specific federal program. They don't have to be. The effective ones are about specific laws.

Here's one from Wicker and Blumenthal https://trucksafety.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/06/Wicker_Blumenthal.jpg

2 more replies



videofoot • 5y ago

Just got around to reading this, hope that you're still replying OP. You mentioned in the comments and in the previous posts the lobbying work done by NGOs such as the Sierra Club. If I am a total newbie to lobbying, is more effective to spend e.g. 20 hours researching and lobbying on an issue or to just donate say \$200 to an NGO that basically advances the same priorities?



FireDistinguishers [OP](#) • 5y ago

I'm always replying.

And that really depends on two factors: if the priorities are exactly yours, and if the group is working at the level of government you want to influence. If they aren't working at the level you care about, or if their priorities differ, you should do it yourself.

Better than money, by the way, is time. If you join as a member of one of these orgs and offer to volunteer as a concerned citizen these guys will absolutely use you as a resource to get meetings with your reps, they'll do a lot of heavy lifting for you, and you'll get professional support in the meeting you're having with your representative. It might only happen like once a year but that's better than nothing.

1 more reply

[Skip to main content](#)[Find anything](#)[Ask](#)[Log In](#)**Photon_in_a_Foxhole** • 5y ago

Politics is for power

**FireDistinguishers** [OP](#) • 5y ago

Never read it do you recommend it

[+ 1 more reply](#)**Cuddlyaxe** • 5y ago

Time to make myself the constitutional grand poobah

**TrekkiMonstr** • 2y ago • Edited 2y ago

Sorry I've been spamming you with questions these last couple days, but I've just finished the whole series, so this is the last one.

[The work cell] is the most coveted method of contact because it's on us 24/7, and if a constituent is calling it we can't ignore them.

Is this a legal thing like the meetings in general, or is this just a matter of you're required (by what?) to pick up that phone no matter what? Also, for the meetings in general, do you happen to have a citation for the right to meet? I couldn't find it.

In that scenario, be as respectfully pursuant to a meeting with them anyway.

Also, I think I'm dumb, but what does this sentence mean? Are you saying meet with your rep even if you didn't intend to and were redirected there?

Senate emails are more distinct and depend on knowing who the individual person works for. Same thing, if my legal name was Fire Distinguishers, but the year is 2007 and I work in the Senate for Biden, my email would be fire_distinguishers@biden.senate.gov.

Does the format depend on the office, or just the subdomain? That is, is it always [firstname]_[lastname]@[senator].senate.gov, or might some offices use [firstinitial][lastname] or [firstname].[lastname] as in the House?

If they don't immediately say yes, be respectful of their time but keep asking for meetings.

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one? (That is, nothing will have happened since your last meeting, except, hopefully, progress towards a solution on the legislative side.)

WARNING: Unless you have a legal background, don't bring anyone legal writing. 60% of the time it's committee staff who handle that kind of thing anyway, and the other 40% of the time the work is being done in conjunction with their chamber's legal support office and the Congressional Research Service. Legal writing will be ignored.

How commonly do professional lobbyists write language? When does it become appropriate to do so?

Also, dumb question, but what is the dress code here? How much will it hurt to be wearing less than a suit (or the female equivalent)?

And, your lobbyist friend -- how did they get to that position? Do you know what it's like to work in the industry (hours, pay, etc)? I'd like to have an impact on the country/world, but I'd also like to have money in my 20s, you know?

Now that I've been promoted

I'm almost three years late, but congratulations lol

They should give me a fucking medal for this.

[Here you go](#)

Edit: also, with regards to getting contact information, why do you suggest working your way up from a call to the office, rather than just paying for a directory? From the perspective of the LC/LA receiving an email, isn't it the same either way? And when is it appropriate to go to an LA, rather than an LC? Also, what do you do if you want to lobby for multiple issues which are covered by the same person? And, just to confirm, all the legislative staff are in DC, yes? That is, there's no one to meet at the district office, so it's fly out or Zoom? Sorry again for the thousand questions.



FireDistinguishers OP · 2y ago

Is this a legal thing like the meetings in general, or is this just a matter of you're required (by what?) to pick up that phone no matter what? Also, for the meetings in general, do you happen to have a citation for the right to meet? I couldn't find it.

I used to think it was a legal thing, until I worked for a shitty office. Turns out it's a norm of behavior, but one of the biggest lines you can't cross. You don't want someone from the State (or district) going around saying "look how unresponsive Senator X's staff is!" It makes the boss look bad, and making the boss look bad is how people get fired.

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It means even if you have no legal right to a meeting with someone, you should still try and meet with them by pursuing their time, respectfully since they're not obliged to sit down with you in the same way as staff. Again, more normative than legal, which I realized under tragic circumstances.

Does the format depend on the office, or just the subdomain? That is, is it always [firstname]_[lastname]@[senator].senate.gov, or might some offices use [firstinitial][lastname] or [firstname].[lastname] as in the House?

All offices use that exact denotation in the Senate, and the same applies to the version described in the House. The only time there's variation is if somebody shares the same first and last name as somebody else who had/has that email. Have never seen that happen in any of my offices though so I don't know how they change it.

What does this look like in practice? I can't visualize how to go about this without being annoying. And regarding building a relationship, what do meetings after the first one look like? Once you've said your spiel, what is left for future meetings? You elaborate on this a bit later, but what if your issue is a static one? (That is, nothing will have happened since your last meeting, except, hopefully, progress towards a solution on the legislative side.)

I think you should be annoying. I don't mean be entitled, but it's your government. As for meetings after the first, honestly that depends more on how the first one went. You could honestly word for word make the exact same pitch again if there's no movement, but you're trying to convince them so you just have to trust your instincts on that front.

How commonly do professional lobbyists write language? When does it become appropriate to do so?

Honestly, a lot more than otherwise. They usually submit Technical Draft Assistance, which might include some legal language, and it might outright be the phrasing they want in statute, which helps things get through the Office of Legislative Services faster. That being said, we still send it to Leg. Services, so it's more a question of speed than workload.

Also, dumb question, but what is the dress code here? How much will it hurt to be wearing less than a suit (or the female equivalent)?

Extremely formal in the Senate, less formal in the House but still more formal than most other places. The joke is that the Senate will be the last place in the country where "dressing casually" means taking off your suit jacket. On Fridays in the House sometimes some people wear jeans. Either way, when we're in session, everybody's dressed like it's the 40s.

And, your lobbyist friend -- how did they get to that position? Do you know what it's like to work in the industry (hours, pay, etc)? I'd like to have an impact on the country/world, but I'd also like to have money in my 20s, you know?

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in DC nowadays. Honestly, I'm ignorant about the working conditions, but there's tons of junior staff at firms and what my buddy did was go on open secrets and legistorm and politico, find who the top firms were that quarter, go on linkedin and search up those firms, and then reach out to all the junior people who went to his same undergrad. Made him mega-informed in like 2 weeks.

I'm almost three years late, but congratulations lol

Hey thanks buddy, and thanks for the medal

also, with regards to getting contact information, why do you suggest working your way up from a call to the office, rather than just paying for a directory?

I mean you totally could pay for the info but those directories are insanely expensive (like 20k per person per year) and just calling is free

when is it appropriate to go to an LA, rather than an LC?

My opinion is you should always go to the LA and maybe they'll pass you off to the LC, but let them make that decision. Other people say always go for the LA in the house and start with the LC in the Senate. Other people say go to anybody you can meet with in the House if they have an established portfolio, and LAs/above in the Senate. Honestly there aren't a lot of ways to do this wrong.

Also, what do you do if you want to lobby for multiple issues which are covered by the same person?

Just bring it up. "Hey I also want to talk to you about this other thing"

And, just to confirm, all the legislative staff are in DC, yes? That is, there's no one to meet at the district office, so it's fly out or Zoom?

I don't think there's anything FORCING all the leg staff to be in DC, but i've never heard of leg staff outside DC, and it makes a lot of sense for us all to be here. Shit if you find a leg staffer who's permanently in another office, let me know. That being said, when Congress is out, sometimes some staff will work out of their state/district offices. You'll be able to figure out where someone is and what's viable when you actually set up a meeting.

 3 more replies

Congress ends record-shattering DHS shutdown

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 r/neoliberal · 8mo ago

9th Circuit reverses victory for Trump admin in National Guard case after feds get caught lying

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 r/neoliberal · 2mo ago

the_median_voter.png

1K upvotes · 145 comments



 r/neoliberal · 10mo ago

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126 upvotes · 51 comments



 r/neoliberal · 10mo ago

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 r/neoliberal · 2y ago

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After extensive scientific study and peer review, I present a guide to how Canadian Prime Ministers would respond to children yelling "McDonalds! McDonalds!"

279 upvotes · 78 comments



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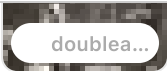
appointment powers?

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 r/neoliberal · 2d ago

The founder of the federalist, followed by JD Vance, is calling for the sterilization of all tourists.

1K upvotes · 338 comments



 r/neoliberal · 4d ago

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 r/neoliberal · 2d ago

14th Amendment

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723 upvotes · 474 comments

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Supreme Court allows states to count mail-in ballots that arrive late, rejecting RNC challenge

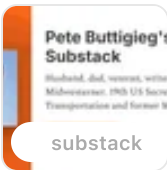
657 upvotes · 97 comments



 r/neoliberal · 6d ago

A Terrible Thing Happened to My Family

629 upvotes · 129 comments



 r/neoliberal · 2d ago

Free trade, open borders, maternity wards on every corner



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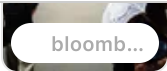


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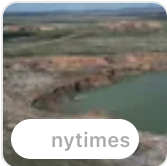


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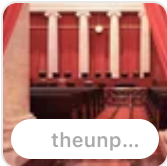


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